Other historians – notably Sergei Radchenko – have challenged the evidence on which it is claimed Khrushchev took his decision out of a romantic attachment to the Cuban revolution rather than a hard-headed appreciation of the strategic nuclear balance.[59] It is interesting to note how decades of research and revelation have not agreed on a basic question about the crisis (although it has facilitated nuanced and informed debate and analysis). What research into the Soviet side has achieved is clarity about the role of Nikita Khrushchev. Before and during the crisis there was speculation that Khrushchev acted because he was under pressure from 'hardliners.' What is clear is that while he needed the approval of the Presidium, key decisions were driven by his judgements – from deploying the missiles, to using secrecy and deception, to retreating in the face of war.

Khrushchev recounts in his memoirs that he thought of sending missiles to Cuba during a visit to Bulgaria in May 1962. On his return he floated the idea with Marshal Malinovsky. On 20 May Khrushchev discussed the suggestion with senior colleagues – Anastas Mikoyan, Marshal Malinovsky, Andrei Gromyko, Fred Kozlov (commonly viewed as his heir apparent), and Aleksandr Alekseev.[60] Alekseev had been the KGB *Rezident* in Havana since 1959. He developed a close relationship with Fidel Castro and was brought back to Moscow to be appointed ambassador to Cuba. When asked how Castro would see the idea of Soviet missiles in Cuba, Alekseev gave Khrushchev the unwelcome opinion that Castro 'will be scared and I don't think he will take them'.[61]

The following day, Khrushchev chaired the Soviet Defence Council, which included Mikoyan, Malinovsky, and the secretaries of the Central Committee of the CPSU, Kozlov and Leonid Brezhnev. The Defence Council did not rubberstamp Khrushchev's proposal. The secretary of the council [Colonel-General Semyon P. Ivanov] noted that 'the debates went on a long time'. Mikoyan, especially, 'opposed placing our missiles and troops on Cuba.'[62] We do not know the focus of these debates, or the issues raised by the Soviet military. We do know that three days later the General Staff's Main Operations Directorate presented a plan to the Presidium for its approval.